Sharma did not survive the Raje wave sweeping the state at the time.

Later, Sharma managed a seamless return to the BJP. Sources say his dedication to party responsibilities caught the attention of Shah and BJP president J.P. Nadda. Hailing from the eastern region where the BJP has historically been weaker, Sharma's elevation can strengthen the party's foothold there. Another significant factor in Sharma's ascent was state general secretary (organisation) Chandrashekhar, who is said to have played a decisive role in advocating the fellow Brahmin's name. Tasked with rebuilding the BJP minus Raje's supporters in 2017, Chandrashekhar's views held sway among the party leadership, furthering Sharma's cause. However, now that he has been appointed as the Brahmin CM of Rajasthan, Sharma's elevation is likely to throw the future of other Brahmin leaders—state president C.P. Joshi among them—into uncertainty, especially as the Lok Sabha election draws near. Chandrashekhar may be assigned a role elsewhere.

However, having arrived at his destination, Sharma's journey from here on will be paved with challenges. Among the first of these will arise from the fact that he as well as his deputies are from constituencies in Jaipur district, creating a regional imbalance that will have to be addressed during cabinet formation. This oversight obtains in the current crop of Union ministers as well—Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, Arjun Ram Meghwal and Kailash Chaudhary—all of whom represent desert constituencies.

HAILING FROM THE EASTERN REGION WHERE THE BJP HAS HISTORICALLY BEEN WEAK, SHARMA IS SEEN AS SOMEONE WHO CAN BOLSTER THE PARTY'S FOOTHOLD THERE

ROSTER OF CHALLENGES

Caste dynamics promise to be a significant stumbling block. The party must navigate the representation for Jats and Gujjars (both OBC), and Meenas (ST) in the cabinet. Sharma will also have to manage the potential discontent among senior leaders, if they are denied cabinet positions, some already having had to give up the chief ministerial ambitions they themselves may have nursed. A prominent leader, however, bats for Sharma, saying, "He is a simple man focused on his duty, who lives in a modest flat, where one of the lifts was repaired only after his name was announced as CM," and ruling out any possibility of him having an ego clash with party veterans. The murmurs of protests, though, have already begun rising. Let us see how he acts once he is in power, many a leader and their fans are asking on social media. And whether being an experienced MLA or minister or a popular leader is now a disadvantage in the BJP when Modi himself has been in power for the longest time when seen against party history.

The RSS and the party high command are expected to ultimately play a crucial role in assigning portfolios and selecting key bureaucrats, tasks that are typically under the purview of the CM. It's also not the MLAs who have selected Sharma; he has been 'chosen' by the party's top echelon. Formal consent from the MLAs was sought only ex post facto. The prolonged silence from them is indicative of disapproval. The BJP leadership, however, knows such disapproval is short-lived.

Senior leaders may be waiting for the new CM to fail, given his lack of experience. His first test will be the upcoming general election. In 2013 and 2018, the party had won all 25 parliamentary seats in the state. His opponents, though, may be in for a disappointment—fresh incumbents learn fast when in power. The BJP also has the knack of guiding newly appointed leaders into becoming able administrators. Many within the party are also pleased that Modi-Shah continue a tradition where any party worker can rise to power. Sharma is a humble man from a lower middle-class background, who earns an income from modest agricultural land and a small business supplying agricultural produce. A senior officer, who interacted with him during his tenure in Bharatpur, reveals how he even lacked resources for his children's education at one time. But under that humility could well lie steely resolve. He is said to listen to everyone before taking any decision, but once it is made, he is stubbornly final about it. He is also very determined, finishing every task that he is either assigned or has set for himself. It's what the RSS likes about him. It should serve the state well too. ■

IN FOR A BUMPY RIDE

CRIME AND CORRUPTION
Rajasthan ranks among the worst states for serious crimes such as gang violence and rapes. The politician-middleman-bureaucrat nexus needs to be dismantled to combat corruption, something the BJP has repeatedly emphasised

MANAGING VETERANS
Will have to take along party leaders, many from the Raje faction, overlooked in cabinet formation. Will also have to address regional imbalance given that he and his deputies are from Jaipur district

FISCAL STRESS
With a debt-GSDP ratio of around 40 per cent, Rajasthan's finances are under severe stress—exacerbated by high debt, particularly in the power sector and allocations for welfare programmes